

ARTICLES IN ENGLISH

THREE MAIN RULES

1. When we say what people's jobs are, we use a/an

- *She's an architect.*
- *He's a doctor.*
- *My grandfather was a teacher.*

2. Singular, countable nouns always have an article - a/an or the - or another determiner (my, your, this, that etc.)

Remember that we use the indefinite article - a/an - when we talk about something that is not definite.

- *I saw a good film yesterday. The listener doesn't know which film.*
- *There's a man at the door. We don't know who the man is.*
- *Do you want a drink? It's not a particular drink.*

... and we use the definite article - the - when we talk about something more certain.

- *I'm going to take the dog for a walk. The dog is a pet - it's not just any dog.*
- *Have you seen the car key? Speaker and listener know which car. It's not just any car.*
- *They live in the house opposite ours. There's only one house opposite. It's not any house.*

3. When we talk about things in general we usually use a plural noun or an uncountable noun with no article.

- *Birds eat worms. NOT ~~The birds eat the worms.~~*
- *Water flows downhill.*
- *Kangaroos live in Australia.*

BUT *We went to the zoo and saw the kangaroos.* These are particular kangaroos in a particular zoo - not kangaroos in general.

reduce the number of mistakes you make.

OTHER RULES FOR THE USE OF ARTICLES.

4. **Special places**: In expressions with a number of places there is **no article** after a preposition.

These places include: *to/at school, to/at university/college, to/in church, to/in/out of prison, to/in hospital, to/in/out of bed, to/at work, at home.*

- *My son's **at university** but my daughter still goes **to school**.*
- *He was sent **to prison** for 10 years.*
- *Now that winter's here I find it difficult to get out of **bed**.*

5. **Methods of transport** (*by bus, by train, by car, by plane, by bicycle, on foot*) **no article**.

- *I hate travelling **by train**.*
- *I go to work **by bus** but I go home **on foot**.*
BUT 'go home' has neither 'the' nor 'to'.

6. **Geography**

No article - continents (Africa, Asia etc.) **countries** (France, Germany etc - but the United States, the United Kingdom) **towns & cities** (Caerphilly, Cardiff, London etc.) **lakes** (Lake Victoria, Lake Windemere etc.) **universities** (Oxford University, Cardiff University etc.)

Use 'the' - seas & oceans (the Atlantic, the Mediterranean etc.) **mountain ranges** (the Himalayas, the Brecon Beacons) **rivers** (the Amazon, the Danube etc.)

7. **Other expressions**

*I don't watch television very often but I listen to the radio all the time.
I've got a headache. I've got a stomach-ache. I've got a cold.*

BUT

*I've got 'flu.
I've got earache.
I've got toothache.*

8. NEVER WITH MEALS

I have breakfast at 7am.

I'm going out for dinner on Friday night.

I had lunch yesterday with Mary.

9. DAYS & DATES

On Monday; On Monday the 17th of November _____(when speaking) but

On Monday 17th November _____ (when writing).

On the 17th November _____

In November

In 2016

During the twentieth century....

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